because he wanted Kennedy to accept his proposal, which read as follows: “We, for our part, will declare that our ships, bound for Cuba, will not carry any kind of armaments. You would declare that the United States will not invade Cuba with its forces and will not support any sort of forces which might intend to carry out an invasion of Cuba. Then the necessity for the presence of our military specialists in Cuba would disappear.”

What Khrushchev was prepared to offer Kennedy was far short of the mandate given him by the Presidium. He never explicitly admitted the presence of nuclear missiles on the island and never proposed to remove them. Instead, he gave a vague promise to remove “military specialists.” Khrushchev was initiating a bargaining process, his immediate goal being to stop the escalation of the conflict. “Mr. President,” he wrote, “we and you ought not now to pull on the ends of the rope in which you have tied the knot of war, because the more the two of us pull, the tighter that knot will be tied. And a moment may come when that knot will be tied so tight that even he who tied it will not have the strength to untie it, and then it will be necessary to cut that knot, and what that would mean is not for me to explain to you, because you yourself understand perfectly of what terrible forces our countries dispose.”[4]

With the letter signed and delivered to the American embassy, all that remained for Khrushchev to do was wait. He did not know which would come first, a response or an invasion.

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ON OCTOBER 26 KHRUSHCHEV WAS NOT THE ONLY POLITICAL leader deeply concerned about an impending invasion of Cuba. Even more convinced of its inevitability and concerned about its outcome was Khrushchev’s Cuban ally, Fidel Castro.

Ever since Kennedy’s televised address of October 22, Castro had been trying to reassure his people and rally them around the goal of defending their now socialist *patria*. He had put the Cuban military forces on high alert a few hours before Kennedy’s speech, anticipating that the address would deal with Cuba. On October 23 Castro gave a lengthy televised